

WEEKLY BUSINESS SESSION - August 26, 2026

9:08 a.m.

Present: Ron Smith, Chair-Commissioner; Colene Martin, Vice-Chair-Commissioner; Gary Richardson, Commissioner; Nikole Guzman, Recorder

These are meeting minutes only. Only text enclosed in quotation marks reports a speaker's exact words.

Items discussed were as follows:

1. CALL MEETING TO ORDER:

Due to a brief power outage, the meeting began at 9:08 a.m. Chair Ron Smith called the Weekly Business Session to order, followed by the Pledge of Allegiance.

2. DECLARE A POTENTIAL CONFLICT OF INTEREST:

Commissioners Richardson, Martin, and Smith each declared no potential conflicts of interest.

3. ADMINISTRATIVE ACTION(S) IN CONSIDERATION OF:

a. Resolution No. 2026-032 - Water/Sewer Infrastructure Extension Funds

Wally Hicks, Legal Counsel, presented Resolution No. 2026-032 supporting Josephine County and the City of Cave Junction in pursuing state funding for planning and engineering related to extending water and sewer infrastructure toward Kirby and the Illinois Valley Airport. He explained that the County and City intend to apply to separate Business Oregon programs and that the resolution documents that, if both applications are successful, the jurisdictions will avoid assigning the same costs to both awards. The Board clarified that the immediate project is planning and engineering only, not construction of infrastructure.

A motion was made and seconded to approve Resolution No. 2026-032. Upon roll call: Commissioner Richardson - Yes; Commissioner Martin - Yes; Commissioner Smith - Yes. Motion carried 3-0.

b. Letter of Support - City of Cave Junction Water/Sewer Infrastructure Extension Funds

Legal Counsel presented the companion letter supporting the City of Cave Junction application. The letter is part of the City application package for the state infrastructure-planning program.

Commissioner Richardson made a motion to approve the letter of support for the City of Cave Junction application. Seconded by Commissioner Martin. Upon roll call: Commissioner Richardson - Yes; Commissioner Martin - Yes; Commissioner Smith - Yes. Motion carried 3-0.

c. Grants Pass Airport - Temporary Runway Closure Lighting and Visual Aid

Airport Manager Michael Crissafulli presented a recommendation to award the purchase of portable runway-closure markers for the Grants Pass Airport Taxiway Extension Project. Three proposals were solicited and two bids were received; the manufacturer, Halibrite, submitted the lowest bid at \$56,691. The purchase had already been included in the previously approved grant agreement. The portable units unfold into large illuminated X markers placed at runway ends and will remain County emergency equipment after construction is completed.

The Board discussed the planned 21 nighttime runway closures, the anticipated construction schedule, FAA NOTAM notification requirements, and the value of having the equipment available for unplanned closures. The Airport Manager stated that daytime operations will remain open during construction except as otherwise required and that the markers can also be transported to the Illinois Valley Airport if needed.

Commissioner Richardson made a motion to approve the recommendation of award and associated contract for the temporary runway-closure lighting and visual-aid equipment. Seconded by Commissioner Martin. Upon roll call: Commissioner Richardson - Yes; Commissioner Martin - Yes; Commissioner Smith - Yes. Motion carried 3-0.

d. Board Order No. 2026-046 - Designation of Josephine County Budget Officer

Legal Counsel explained that Oregon budget law requires the County to formally designate a budget officer. Because the prior temporary Finance Director had left County employment and Matthew Eide is now serving as Finance Director, the Board was asked to designate Mr. Eide as Budget Officer in advance of the supplemental-budget process.

Commissioner Martin made a motion to approve Board Order No. 2026-046 designating Matthew Eide as Josephine County Budget Officer. Seconded by Commissioner Richardson. Upon roll call: Commissioner Richardson - Yes; Commissioner Martin - Yes; Commissioner Smith - Yes. Motion carried 3-0.

4. REQUESTS/COMMENTS FROM CITIZENS:

(Each person was given three (3) minutes to speak.)

Judy Ahrens, Josephine County, expressed concerns regarding public education, student achievement, civic knowledge, and the direction of public policy. She encouraged residents to attend local school board meetings and participate in education governance.

Mike Pelfrey, Josephine County, asked the Board to consider a resolution or policy statement similar to one recently adopted by Douglas County concerning Oregon sanctuary laws. He also expressed concerns regarding crime and requested stronger local law-enforcement responses.

BOARD MAY REVIEW PUBLIC COMMENTS/QUESTIONS:

Commissioner Richardson thanked Ms. Ahrens for her interest in education and discussed current Grants Pass School District 7 policy work and educational initiatives. Regarding the sanctuary-law request, he stated that the issue involves overlapping federal and state authority and that any County resolution would largely be a policy statement rather than a change in applicable law. He emphasized the need to avoid actions that could expose the County to adverse legal consequences.

Commissioner Martin agreed that the Douglas County action was more properly viewed as a policy statement and noted that legal and governmental responses to that action were still developing.

Chair Smith stated that he had obtained and reviewed the Douglas County resolution and discussed it with the Sheriff. He emphasized that a County statement would not change Oregon law or the legal duties of the Sheriff and Board, and said he did not favor placing Josephine County in legal jeopardy for an action that would not change the governing law.

5. APPROVAL OF CONSENT CALENDAR:**a. Minutes (Draft minutes are available for viewing in the Board's Office)**

The Board considered the Consent Calendar consisting of draft minutes from prior meetings as presented.

Commissioner Richardson made a motion to approve the Consent Calendar. Seconded by Commissioner Martin. Upon roll call: Commissioner Richardson - Yes; Commissioner Martin - Yes; Commissioner Smith - Yes. Motion carried 3-0.

6. OTHER: (ORS 192.640(1))

No additional matters requiring Board action were introduced.

7. ANNOUNCEMENTS: MATTERS FROM COMMISSIONERS:

Commissioner Martin announced the grand reopening of Whitehorse Park following renovations and additional camping improvements. A ribbon cutting was scheduled for September 2, 2026, at 11:00 a.m. She recognized the Parks Department and Tamra Martin and staff for their work on the project. Chair Smith also expressed support for the improvements.

Commissioner Richardson presented information regarding Grants Pass High School and School District 7, including recent rankings, graduation rates, college-credit opportunities, and student proficiency measures. He also reminded County employees that the annual benefits enrollment period was underway and encouraged completion by August 31, 2026.

Chair Smith recognized local firefighters, the Sheriff's Office, and other first responders for their response to recent fires near Grants Pass and thanked them for their work protecting residents and property.

Weekly Business Session adjourned at 9:41 a.m.


Nikole Guzman, Recorder